

Kaddish

21a

Version 2

Trad.
Arr. Stuart Izon

There is no authoritative version of this kaddish, though everyone seems to agree on the rough shape of the melody. The oldest part is surely the "ba'agala" motif, and various composers have constructed larger pieces around this theme. Sometimes this motif is written as a waltz, while sometimes it is arranged in 4/4. It is clear to me that this is the same melody as Eliyahu Hanavi from after Havdala (which is always in waltz time). However the thematic connection here is not obvious.

Typically in the US, the melody for the "y'hei sh'mei raba" is the same as the one for the full kaddish at the end of the service, though that is usually in the major, where the chatzi kaddish is in the minor. This abrupt change in tonality has always seemed rather jarring to me. Although this is not a modern mistake as this usage is at least 150 years old, nevertheless I'd argue what we typically encounter in congregations today is unison singing on a harmony line, and because of this, the minor tonality is obscured to the extent that it sounds like we are modulating to the relative major. By comparison, UK congregations typically sing the "ba'agala" motif again for the words "y'hei sh'mei raba". Many of the historical scores I surveyed have their own unique versions of "y'hei sh'mei raba" which bear no resemblance to either of these options.

In many congregations nowadays, the "ba'agala" motif is used for the previous line "b'chayeichon" – this appears not to have been done historically. I found only one example of this; in all the other scores the melody starts at "ba'agala". When the motif returns at the end, about half the the scores had this is at "tushb'chata" and the others start it only at "di amiran".

Finally, there is a common practice to use this kaddish melody for the kaddish following the Torah reading on Shabbat day. How this became established is unclear to me, especially as other kaddishes have their own distinctive, unique melodies (c.f. festivals or Rosh Hashana).

Recitative

Chazzan

mf Yit-ga - dal v' - yit - ka - dash sh'-mei ra - ba

Melody Alto

mp a - men

Tenor Bass

6

C. b' - a - l' - ma di-vra chi-ru - tei v'-yam-lich mal - chu - tei b'-cha-yei -

11

C. -chon uv - yo - mei - chon uv - cha - yei di - chol beit yis - ra - el

15 **Andante**

C.

M
A
mf *mf* v' - im -

T
B

19 **Piu mosso**

C.

M
A
mp *mf*

T
B

23

M
A
p

T
B

27 **Recitative**

C.

Yit - ba - rach v' - yish - ta - bach v' - yit - pa - ar v' - yit - ro-mam v' - yit - na -

31

C.

-sei v' - yit - ha - dar v'-yit - a - lei v' - yit - ha - lal sh'-mei di-ku - d' -

34

C.

-sha b'rich hu l' - ei - la min kol bir-cha - ta v'shi-ra - ta

M
A

mf b'rich hu

T
B

38 **Andante**

M
A

mf tush - b'-cha - ta v' ne - che-ma - ta di - a - mi - ran b' - a - l' -

T
B

41 **Adagio**

C.

p v' - im ru a - men

M
A

-ma *pp* a - men

T
B